

US Classics and French Rivals

By the 1970s light aircraft had become a viable means of reliable transportation. At the start of the decade fuel was still relatively cheap and, when fitted with decent instruments, avionics, and deice systems, many of these machines were quite capable of flying reasonable distances in inclement weather.



△ Avions Pierre Robin CEA DR400 Chevalier 1972

Origin	France
Engine	160 hp Lycoming O-320 air-cooled flat-4
Top speed	145 mph (233 km/h)

Although the light aircraft market was dominated by the US, French airframer Robin produced a range of fine, two- and four-seat low-wing aircraft. A distinctive feature of the primarily wooden DR400 is that it shares the same cranked wing as the Jodel homebuilt.



△ Rockwell International 114A 1972

Origin	USA
Engine	260 hp Lycoming IO-540 air-cooled flat-6
Top speed	191 mph (307 km/h)

Although the Rockwell Commander series were spacious, good-looking machines, they never managed to sell in the same numbers as Beechcraft's Bonanza or Piper's Comanche. Although several attempts have been made to resurrect the marque, so far these have not been successful.

▽ Cessna F177RG Cardinal 1974

Origin	USA design/French built
Engine	200 hp Lycoming IO-360 air-cooled flat-4
Top speed	143 mph (230 km/h)

The 177 was intended to replace the 172, and consequently incorporated several modern features, including a laminar flow airfoil and a cantilever wing. Although not a great seller at the time, it is now viewed as a fine aircraft.



△ Piper PA-34-200T Seneca II 1971

Origin	USA
Engine	2 x 200 hp Continental TSIO-360 turbocharged air-cooled flat-6
Top speed	195 mph (314 km/h)

The Seneca first flew in 1971, and the type remains in production today. The version shown is the Seneca II, which is fitted with turbocharged engines for better performance at high altitude. An interesting facet of the Seneca is that the propellers rotate in opposite directions so there is no critical engine.

▽ Piper PA-28 RT Turbo Arrow IV 1978

Origin	USA
Engine	200 hp Continental TSIO-360 turbocharged air-cooled flat-6
Top speed	161 mph (259 km/h)

A member of Piper's famous PA-28 family, the turbocharged Arrow IV was one of the fastest versions. Although later Arrows—such as the one shown—feature a T-tail, many pilots prefer the handling of earlier models.



△ Cessna 421B 1973

Origin	USA
Engine	2 x 375 hp Continental GTSIO-520 geared, turbocharged air-cooled flat-6
Top speed	276 mph (444 km/h)

Known as the Golden Eagle, the Cessna 421B was derived from the 411, with the primary difference being that it is pressurized. Over 1,900 were built during an 18-year production run.